

and other spiritual symbols to the ceremonial tea house. These gardens are more heavily planted, and include maples (*Acer*), pines, azaleas, and camellias, which are subjected to a tight pruning regime to restrict their size and create miniature forms of larger trees or shrubs. The planting does not focus solely on evergreens and there are splashes of color in the form of cherry blossom and camellias in the spring, elegant summer irises, and the fiery fall foliage of the maples contributing to the seasonal display.

Contemporary gardens

With many of us living increasingly urban lives, contemporary gardens have had to fulfil a number of different functions, providing a space for planting, relaxation, play, and entertaining. Modern urban gardens can differ in emphasis, and be treated either as purely functional spaces in which hard surfaces prevail along with furniture, lighting effects, and water features to create the ultimate outdoor room, or as green oases in which the planting dominates.

The layout of an urban garden is generally based on simple lines, often with an asymmetrical floor plan, and uses a combination of natural and man-made materials, such as concrete, glass, plastic, acrylic, and steel, to provide textural interest. Furniture often takes the form of integral benches, stylishly coordinated tables and chairs, and recliners, while sculpture provides a focal point, and can be combined with water. Jets or cascades are popular, but tanks of reflective water are becoming increasingly popular.

Contemporary planting designs

As space can be limited in today's urban gardens, the planting often focuses on a more limited choice of species, and those that provide architectural interest. Grasses, bamboos, and large-leaved foliage plants, such as the hardy banana (*Musa basjoo*), phormiums, and cordylines are popular in contemporary schemes.

Modernist designs often employ block plantings of plants such as small festucas and ophiopogons. These may be used in conjunction with pleached trees planted along the boundaries to provide privacy in overlooked gardens. Dramatic containers made from clay, stone, or steel can be used as focal points or lined up in a row to add drama and rhythm to the design. Popular plants for containers include clipped topiary box, bay or Japanese holly (*Ilex crenata*), bamboo, succulents like agaves, or bold grasses.



ABOVE Contemporary urban style

This urban, split-level garden, with its smart, outdoor seating, shows how contemporary outdoor areas can function in multiple ways—both as outdoor rooms and areas for lawns and beautiful plants.

BELOW Tropical abundance

The striking leaves of elephant ears (*Alocasia*) provide a dramatic focal point in an exotic, junglelike garden. Bright sparks of color are provided by the vibrant red cannas which stand out amidst the lush green foliage.

Tropical gardens

This style of garden is most suitable for tropical and warm-temperate regions, where the native plants are naturally lush, but a similar effect can be created in cooler climates with the careful selection of plants.

The design is informal, with man-made structures made from rough-hewn timber and unworked stone, reflecting the traditional crafts of people living in tropical environments. Water plays a large part in designs, mimicking the landscapes that inspired the style, with waterfalls, streams, and, occasionally, swimming pools adding to the lush picture.

A tropical garden is a celebration of foliage shapes, textures, and colors. Taller species such as eucalyptus, palms, bamboos, and cordylines provide height, with the space below filled with lower-growing shrubs, grasses, and flowering perennials, such as birds-of-paradise (*Strelitzia*) and streptocarpus.

This exciting look can be created in temperate areas with exotic architectural plants including tree ferns, bamboos, fatsias, ferns, phormiums, and hardy bananas (*Musa basjoo*). For shots of bright detail, use vibrant canna lilies, white arum lilies (*Zantedeschia*), dahlias, crocosmias, agapanthus, and lobelias.

